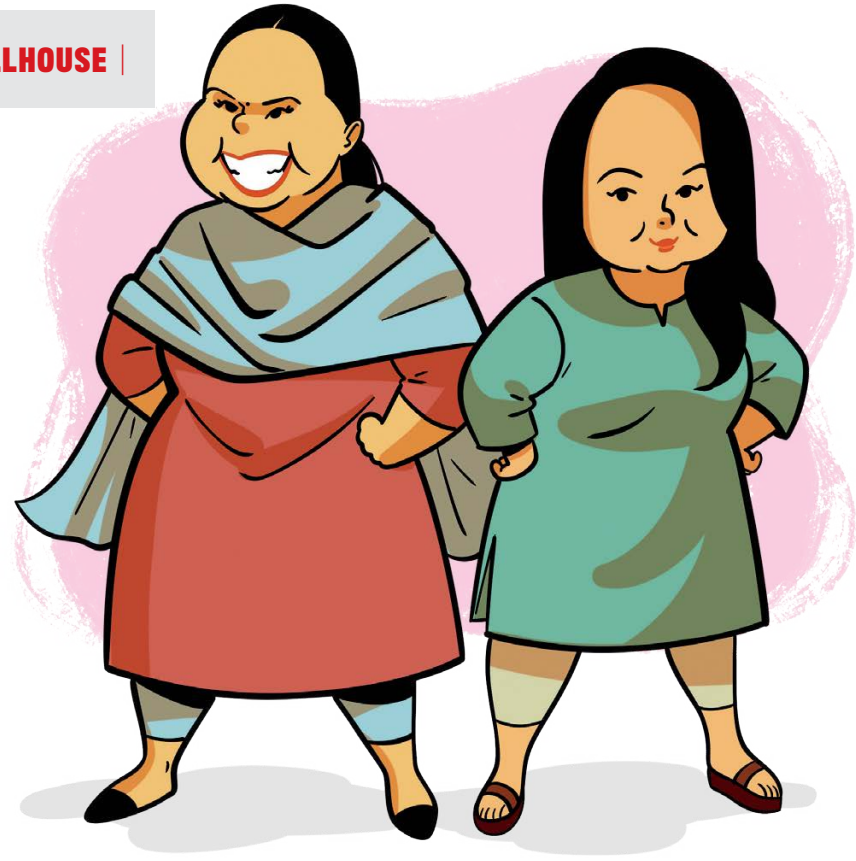


Illustrations by SIDDHANT JUMDE

▶ BIHAR

THE PATALIPUTRIS

A family ballad sung with just that touch of the blue notes. But to help make it less cloying, we get it laced with the edgy feel of ambition, grit, even a hint of vendetta. The unfulfilled saga of Lalu Prasad Yadav's two daughters, **Misa Bharti** and **Rohini Acharya**, is unfolding again, against the backdrop of electoral battlegrounds where their parents faced defeat in the past. Personal stakes and dynastic echoes converge as the two steely women embark on a journey fraught with the weight of past and future. Misa, famously named after the Emergency law, is battling the ghosts of two electoral setbacks at Pataliputra, in 2014 and 2019. Her nemesis on both occasions was party renegade Ram Kirpal Yadav, though the margins were only in the range of 30,000-40,000 votes. Now, she stands close to redemption, seeking to own a political mantle that has long eluded her grasp. Rohini, the feisty daughter who donated her kidney to save Lalu, charts her course in Saran—birthplace of the iconic Jayaprakash Narayan. That's where her mother faced defeat at the hands of the BJP's Rajiv Pratap Rudy in 2014. Saran votes on May 20 and Pataliputra goes down to the wire, staying on slow boil till the seventh phase on June 1. With the memory of their ailing father being sent to jail, and the ever-hovering eye of the agencies, this one's as much for filial honour as the nation. ■

▶ PUNJAB

DOING THE HANS WALK

The BJP bathed in Sufiana? Might seem to strain credulity at first.... But then, we're on **Hans Raj Hans**, the long-haired Sufi pop singer-turned-MP who's just been plucked out of his old North West Delhi seat and paradropped into the complex heart of Punjab: Faridkot. In the southwest of the state, Faridkot is heir to a richly eclectic legacy, being named after the storeyed 12th century Sufi saint Sheikh Fariduddin Ganjshakar a.k.a. Baba Farid. In short, right up the alley for the burly minstrel. So, Hans did his old Hans walk and set things rolling with an obeisance at Tilla Baba Farid, even taking a vow to stay barefoot while in the constituency. Lest that be deemed

